

The early Islamic world

In the early 7th century, the new religion of Islam, founded by the Prophet Muhammad, began to spread through the Arabian Peninsula. By the end of the century, Islam had spread to the north coast of Africa and parts of Central Asia through military conquest and trade. This Islamic Empire continued to grow over the following centuries.

The Islamic Caliphate (empire) was ruled by a series of caliphs (leaders). Muhammad's successors established the Rashidun Caliphate, which ruled until 661. The empire expanded rapidly as powerful Muslim armies conquered land across the Middle East, including in Persia, Syria, and Egypt.

The Umayyad Dynasty then came to power, and advanced further into North Africa and as far as Spain.

The empire reached its peak under the Abbasid Dynasty in the 8th century, when it was one of the largest the world had ever seen, stretching from southern Europe across North Africa and much of Asia. The early Abbasids oversaw a golden age of learning and scientific progress. Yet gradually they lost territory and were finally overthrown by an invading Mongol army in the mid-13th century.



Caliph Harun al-Rashid ruled the Abbasid Dynasty from 786 to 809, at the start of the Islamic golden age.

◀ ABBASID CALIPHATE

The Abbasid Dynasty seized power in 750 and established Baghdad (in modern-day Iraq) as their capital. Scientists, philosophers, scholars, and artists gathered in the city during what became known as the Islamic golden age. The caliphate ended when the Mongol army invaded in 1258 (see p.88).

▼ UMAYYYAD CALIPHATE

After the death of the last Rashidun caliph in 661, Syrian governor Mu'awiya took power. He became the first caliph of the Umayyad Dynasty, and moved the capital to Damascus. The Dome of the Rock shrine—one of Islam's holiest sites—was built in the city of Jerusalem by the Umayyads in the late 7th century.



▲ MAP OF THE EARLY ISLAMIC EMPIRE

During the early years of Islamic rule, Muslim armies conquered large areas of the Middle East, North Africa, and Central Asia. As the empire grew, goods were traded across continents and Islamic culture and beliefs spread farther eastwards. It also led to great advances in maths, science, and the arts.

